also visible to the men at Bridge 4. Chaudhary radioed Lieutenant Colonel Mishra, saying that it looked as if the Chinese were concentrating almost an entire battalion against his position.

As dawn broke on the horizon, 2 Rajput's No. 9 Platoon of Charlie Company, led by Subedar Dashrath Singh, also crossed the Nam Ka Chu at the Temporary Bridge and occupied the grazing ground opposite that was marked on the maps as 'Green Patch'. Other than the sound of the river, there was complete silence in the valley. In their assembly area, the rest of 2 Rajput were preparing to move; Charlie Company under Major S. S. Sethi was to lead, with Bravo Company under Captain Ravi Eipe following behind. Alpha Company was to be the third group which would come into play once Thagla had been occupied. They were to be followed by Battalion HQ with Delta Company. The corps commander, GOC 4 Division, the brigade commander, the BGS (Brigadier K. K. Singh, who had also moved up to Nam Ka Chu) were all at Bridge 4, from where they had a commanding view of the unfolding drama.

At 5 a.m., as Charlie Company approached the Temporary Bridge which was the designated crossing point guarded by Dashrath's platoon, the Chinese opened up with a barrage of heavy and medium mortars, directing their fire at Major Chaudhary's patrol that was holding Tseng Jong. Kaul, who had just started his morning shave, was staring open-mouthed across the river towards the flashes of mortar fire and the exploding bombs. 'Oh my god, you are right—they mean business,' was all that he could gasp, as the myth, carefully perpetuated by New Delhi, that the Chinese would not react, came crashing down with the mortar bombs that were falling around the hastily prepared defences of the Punjabis.

The next thirty minutes were to be a watershed of sorts in modern warfare. No commander had so obviously deflated in front of his officers as Kaul did that morning—gone was his bluster of the previous day. Sensing his opportunity, Dalvi prompted Niranjan Prasad to speak to the corps commander again, in the faint hope that even at this late stage, he would see the situation for what it was. For the first time, Kaul actually seemed to be hearing what Prasad was saying, and Dalvi joined in to reiterate what he had said many times before.

Kaul and the others watched the intensive barrage that continued for thirty minutes, while the Chinese infantry tried to close in. The moment the mortars ceased firing, the Chinese put in their first attack. The leading